The quest for technology and best practices is even visible in the PM's itinerary abroad, whether it related to a battery storage facility in the US, river cleaning in South Korea, bullet trains in Japan, skill development in Singapore, or railway stations in Germany. As this mindset was applied outwards, it also witnessed the export of projects, products and services that spoke of India's improved abilities. This includes a range of infrastructure, connectivity and public facilities that extend from South Asia to Africa and Latin America and, not least, a steady increase in defence exports to a growing list of nations.

The aggregate result is a developing perception of India as a partner of growing consequence. This has helped exports and market access abroad, with beneficial consequences at home. When a PM personally engages with all his ambassadors in that regard, we really know that India is changing.

In many ways, the operational culture of foreign-policy decision-making has adjusted to the new era. Central to that endeavour is a conscious effort to overcome silos by tighter coordination, more intensive strategizing and stronger feedback. Whether it is global trade negotiations, national security situations or multilateral concerns of development, the emphasis is on collective deliberations and decision-making. Starting as it does from ministers and secretaries, this has had a natural impact on the bureaucracy at large.

The same outlook is also demonstrated in respect of important partners and key issues. We see this now in respect of a multi-ministerial interaction with Singapore, the Trade and Technology Council format with the EU and the 2+2 Ministerial Dialogues in Defence and External Affairs with key nations. Behind that process was also a deliberative exercise that sought to prioritize, maximize and intensify India's international relationships. It could be the attention given to leadership-level exchanges, including to the chief guest for the Republic Day, and how they fit in with the larger game plan. Where feedback was concerned, the national-level Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI) exercise was customized for the objectives of foreign policy. Drilling deep down to specifics enabled delays, roadblocks and policy obstacles to be identified and addressed. As a result, many development projects abroad began witnessing more efficient execution.

The systemic improvements came into full play during Covid, whether it was in the Vande Bharat Mission or the Vaccine Maitri initiative. They